

Cigna

CLINICAL COVERAGE DETERMINATION GUIDELINE

Orthopedic Surgery: Knee Arthroscopy

Policy: POL-SURG-340 | Effective: 2026-02-15 | Surgery

COVERED PROCEDURES

- 29881 - Arthroscopy, knee, meniscectomy including partial meniscectomy
- 29880 - Arthroscopy, knee, meniscectomy with meniscus repair
- 29882 - Arthroscopy, knee, meniscectomy medial AND lateral
- 29883 - Arthroscopy, knee, meniscectomy medial AND lateral with repair

DIAGNOSIS CODES

- M23.201 - Derangement of unspecified lateral meniscus, right knee
- M23.211 - Derangement of anterior horn lateral meniscus, right knee
- M23.221 - Derangement of posterior horn lateral meniscus, right knee
- M23.301 - Other meniscus derangements, right knee
- M23.311 - Other meniscus derangements, medial meniscus, right knee
- S83.201A - Unspecified tear of lateral meniscus, right knee, initial
- S83.211A - Bucket-handle tear of lateral meniscus, right knee, initial
- M17.11 - Primary osteoarthritis, right knee
- M17.12 - Primary osteoarthritis, left knee

MEDICAL NECESSITY CRITERIA

All of the following must be documented for approval:

CRIT-1

Failed conservative treatment: minimum 6 weeks of physical therapy, NSAIDs, and activity modification

Threshold: 6 weeks

CRIT-2

Mechanical symptoms present: locking, catching, giving way, or inability to fully extend/flex

Threshold: true

CRIT-3

MRI findings consistent with meniscal tear (signal abnormality extending to articular surface)

Threshold: MRI showing meniscal pathology

CRIT-4

Patient age under 65 OR if over 65, evidence that symptoms are primarily mechanical (not degenerative arthritis)

Threshold: under 65 or documented mechanical etiology

CRIT-5

BMI under 40 OR if BMI over 40, documented weight management program participation

Threshold: BMI < 40 or weight management documented

CRIT-6

Surgeon is board-certified orthopedic surgeon with arthroscopy privileges

Threshold: board-certified orthopedic

URGENT BYPASS

Locked knee with inability to extend - authorize expedited review within 24 hours.

DENIAL REASONS

- Insufficient conservative therapy (less than 6 weeks PT documented)
- No mechanical symptoms - isolated pain without locking/catching
- No MRI or MRI negative for meniscal pathology
- Age >65 with primary osteoarthritis and no mechanical symptoms (arthroscopy not beneficial for degenerative disease)
- BMI >40 without documented weight management

